plan even though we knew it would come up for some serious debate. The designated 'enemy' or Red Land commander was Maj Gen Bhinder, who was the GOC 31 Armoured Division of South-Western Command.[2] He came to me wanting to know if there was anything in particular that I would like him to do. I told him that I could not possibly dictate what the enemy could or could not do and gave him a free hand. I never asked him his plans until they were played, and that too in my capacity as Control. My Control was headed by Brig Mohit Malhotra, Commander 16 (I).[3] Acutely conscious of my experiences in Eastern Command, I gave him a free hand too, to evaluate each engagement purely on merit. All in all, the WG went off well, the Chief was satisfied and he remarked in private to the Army Commander that I seemed to have 'taken to mechanized warfare like a duck to water' (as told to me later by the Army Commander). The DGMO, Maj Gen Ranbir Singh,[4] who had done the HC course with me, called up to say that the Chief had told him that it was a professionally conducted WG. He rang off by saying that now that the WG, the most important event in a Corps Commander's tenure was over, what was I going to do the rest of the time?!

I did not have to wait long to find out. February 2016 also saw the Jat agitation, a series of violent protests in the state of Haryana, which paralysed the state for ten days. At least twenty people died and over 200 were injured when they went on a frenzy of destruction to demand reservations in government jobs for their community. There were also unconfirmed reports of mass rapes. The agitators laid siege to Rohtak and blocked the National Highway between Delhi and Ambala in the vicinity of Murthal. They also blocked the railway line, disrupting rail traffic and leading to the cancellation of almost all trains. We had started getting calls from the civil administration asking for

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